

commission in the armed forces, including combat roles. Additionally, states and UT have been advised to increase female representation to 33% in their police forces; and, (iv) Labour law reforms: The Occupational Safety and Health Code, 2020, entitles women to be employed in all establishments for all types of work, including night shifts, with safety measures.

Economic Initiatives

Women entrepreneurs and workers benefit from government initiatives that provide financial assistance and employment guarantees, such as:

- Pradhan Mantri Mudra Yojana & Stand-Up India: These offer collateral-free, subsidised credit to help women start and scale businesses
- MGNREGA 2005: Mandates that at least one-third of jobs under the scheme be allocated to women
- Skill Development and Digital Literacy: Initiatives like Skill India and Digital Saksharta Abhiyan are equipping women with essential skills for the modern workforce

India vs. Global Trends

While India has made remarkable strides, there is still ground to cover compared to global averages. The International Labour Organization reports a global LFPR at about 49% in 2024. India's female LFPR, while significantly improved, remains slightly below this global benchmark.

A notable trend is the increasing participation of educated women. PLFS data shows that:

- 39.6% of women with postgraduate degrees or higher were working in FY24, against 34.5% in FY18.
- 23.9% of women with higher secondary education were employed in 2023-24, up from 11.4% in 2017-18.

The rise in women joining Global Capability Centres, engineering, IT, and R&D sectors is fuelling economic growth and positioning India as a global innovation hub.



Achieving the 70% workforce participation target by 2047 will require sustained efforts across multiple dimensions, such as strengthening childcare

Addressing Barriers

Despite these, challenges remain. Data from PLFS 2020-24 shows the primary reasons women stay out of the workforce. Childcare and homemaking responsibilities continue to be the biggest barriers, cited by 45.15% of women in 2022-23. Encouragingly, this fell to 43% in 2023-24, indicating incremental progress.

To support women balancing work and home responsibilities, the government has implemented several policies, such as: (a) Maternity and Adoption Leave: The Maternity Benefit (Amendment) Act, 2017 increased paid maternity leave to 26 weeks; (b) Crèche Facilities: Establishments with 50 or more employees must provide childcare facilities; (c) Equal Pay: The Code on Wages, 2019, prohibits gender-based wage discrimination and ensures fair recruitment practices.

The Road Ahead

PLFS data confirms that India's female workforce participation is on an upward trajectory. Government interventions have been pivotal in driving this transformation.

Achieving the 70% workforce participation target by 2047 will require sustained efforts across multiple dimensions, such as strengthening childcare support, enhancing flexible work policies, investing in digital and STEM education to prepare more women for high-skill jobs, encouraging private sector diversity hiring through policy nudges.

With continued momentum and strategic interventions, India is on the right path toward gender-inclusive economic growth. By unlocking the hidden potential of millions of women, India can accelerate its journey to becoming a global economic powerhouse by 2047. **BT**

Views are personal